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Interview 1¹ - Client Problem Identification

Interviewer:

Thank you for taking the time to talk with me about this project today.

Could you explain the current problem you're facing with the existing software and what specifically you're trying to manage with this software?

Client:

The current software we're using is a local OA software based in China.

Interviewer:

Can you explain what an OA is?

Client:

It is an Office Automation Software

It should cover some basic functionalities like posting messages and managing staff information, but the product right now, it's too generalized and lacks the flexibility we need.

For example, we need to manage things like human resources data, attendance, staff performance evaluations, and salary calculations.

Right now, everything feels cluttered and unorganized. Finding specific information is harder than it should be, which makes the process inefficient.

Interviewer:

What specific software are you using right now for these tasks?

Client:

We're using a Chinese-based OA system. It's quite rigid in its features, and there's very little room to customize it according to our company's specific needs. That's a major issue for us.

Interviewer:

¹ Interview transcription has been translated from Chinese (Simplified) to English through translation services.

Could you elaborate on the specific problems you're encountering with the current software?

Client:

Yes, mainly it's the lack of flexibility.

The software is structured in a way where we can't add or remove functionalities based on our needs.

Also, it's too cluttered.

For instance, when we want to look up something in the knowledge base or review staff data, the menus are difficult to navigate and it's easy to get lost in the interface.

It's time-consuming, and for a company with multiple departments, this just doesn't work efficiently.

Interviewer:

What functionalities should be implemented in the new software to potentially solve these problems?

Client:

First, we need a more organized layout where the main features are easy to access, especially for managers.

We need more flexibility in adding or removing certain features as the company grows. Another must-have is to make the HR features better.

This includes handling salary calculations, attendance tracking, and performance evaluations.

Lastly, the knowledge base needs to be searchable, so employees can quickly find the information they need.

Interviewer:

What basic functionalities do you believe are essential for the software?

Client:

The most basic functionalities would include attendance recording, a knowledge base where managers can post and staff can search for instructions, HR management for staff details, salary computation, and a performance evaluation system.

Interviewer:

Do you think the styling of the UI would make a difference? If so, what kind of style would you prefer?

Client:

At this stage, it is optional but it would be a nice feature to have.

We would want something minimalistic and modern because the current software feels too formal and cluttered, which makes it difficult to navigate.

A minimalistic design with simple navigation would make the experience much better.

Interviewer:

Are there any additional features not included in the original software that you'd like in the new version?

Client:

We would like account classification so that different ranks have different access permissions.

For example, HR should have access to all employee data, but regular employees should only have access to their own information.

Interviewer:

How large is the group of employees that will be using the software?

Client:

We have about 200-250 employees across various departments. It's important that the software is able to handle this number and grows with the company.

Interviewer:

Ok. I will reach back out to you after I summarize this meeting.

Client:

Sounds good, looking forward to hear back.

Interview 2² - Success Criteria Proposal

Interviewer:

Now that we have a better understanding of the problem, let's talk about what success looks like for the new software.

Could you help me define what the most important success criteria would be?

Client:

The main thing for us is to have a minimalistic and simple design that highlights the main features we need,

Like HR functions and knowledge base.

It also shouldn't be difficult to find things, and the interface should feel clean.

Interviewer:

How important is flexibility in the features?

Client:

It's crucial.

We need to be able to add or remove features as we go.

For example, if we want to implement a new budgeting tool or performance evaluation process in the future, we need the flexibility to integrate that without having to start from scratch.

Interviewer:

You mentioned access restrictions. How do you want that to look?

Client:

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We'd like to have account levels.

For example, HR staff should have access to everyone's data, while regular employees should only see their own information.

This would ensure sensitive data like salary and performance reviews are secure.

Interviewer:

What about human resources information? What specifically needs to be stored and accessible?

Client:

The system should be able to store detailed staff information such as personal details, attendance records, salary data, and performance evaluations.

Managers and HR staff should be able to access and update this information as needed.

Interviewer:

How will you determine if the salary computation feature is functioning properly?

Client:

The salary computation feature must be accurate and flexible enough to account for different salary structures, deductions, and bonuses.

We'll test it by inputting different salary models and ensuring that it calculates everything correctly based on the rules we provide such as departments and department specific pay.

Interviewer:

How important is performance evaluation, and how should it function?

Client:

It's very important. Managers should be able to input performance reviews, and these should be stored in the system.

Only authorized personnel, like HR or department heads, should be able to view these evaluations.

It should also be possible to generate reports based on these evaluations.

Interviewer:

And for attendance, how will the system manage that?

Client:

Each employee's attendance should be recorded and stored in the database.

HR and managers should be able to easily access and review this data to ensure that performance evaluations and salary decisions are based on actual attendance records.

Interviewer:

You mentioned department-specific access earlier. How will this work for different departments?

Client:

Each department will have its own materials, and only the staff from that department should be able to access them.

For example, the HR department might have sensitive documents that other departments shouldn't access.

At the same time, we want the ability to view all staff data collectively when needed like their pay, their attendance, their information like previous jobs, and many more.

Interviewer:

Finally, how will we know that the software is capable of handling your entire staff?

Client:

We expect the system to handle data for around 200-250 employees across different departments. It should be able to manage this amount of data without slowing down or having any stability issues.

Interviewer:

Thank you so much for your time, I will be in touch with you once the project is in full development.

Client:

Thank you.

Interview 3³ - Client Product Review

Interviewer:

Let's begin the walkthrough.

Client:

The language used is Java, correct?

Interviewer:

Yes, that's correct. I'll show you the program. This is the main interface after opening the program.

Client:

Alright, I can see the home page.

Interviewer:

The program flow is as follows: After login, users are directed to the main dashboard. There are three roles – Admin, Manager, and Employee. Admin has the highest level of access, followed by Manager and Employee.

Client:

Is the frontend currently not separated from the backend? Is there any plan to transition it to a web-based platform?

Interviewer:

Currently, it's not web-based, but theoretically, it could be implemented via localhost.

Client:

Understood. Let's proceed with the login.

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Interviewer:

After logging in, users arrive at the dashboard. The first module is the messaging system, where users can post messages that will be displayed for everyone.

Client:

Are these messages targeted to specific users or visible to all?

Interviewer:

Currently, it functions as an announcement board where all users can view all messages.

Client:

Alright, understood.

Interviewer:

Next is the HR module. Here, Admin can manage departments. I've set up two departments – IT and Marketing – as test entries. The pie chart dynamically updates based on the data inputted for each category.

Client:

So, any changes to the budget are reflected in the chart?

Interviewer:

Correct. Additionally, Admin can create new budget categories and adjust values for each department.

Client:

And employee salaries?

Interviewer:

Yes, the bonus calculation module allows Admin to input salary figures and calculate annual bonuses.

Client:

What about individual employee information? Is it consolidated in one view?

Interviewer:

Employee information is displayed in a table with fields like name, department, date of birth, and salary. Currently, this data is retrieved in real-time from the database.

Client:

Would it be possible to consolidate all this data into a single, comprehensive personnel profile like a form?

Interviewer:

Yes, that's a feasible addition. Currently, the data is shown in the database format and not a form format.

Client:

Noted. Let's move on.

Interviewer:

The Attendance module allows managers or HR to log attendance for each employee. Attendance data can be reviewed and is integrated with the performance evaluation module.

Client:

Is the date format validated?

Interviewer:

Yes, the date format follows the standard YYYY-MM-DD structure and is validated through Java LocalDate to prevent invalid entries.

Client:

Got it. And the evaluation module?

Interviewer:

Managers can evaluate only employees within their department. Admins can view and manage all evaluations.

Client:

Is there any targeted messaging for specific departments or users?

Interviewer:

No, at present, all messages are visible to all users.

Client: Understood. Let's wrap it up.

Interviewer: That covers the essential functionalities. All 11 success criteria have been addressed, and further amendments will be documented if necessary. Thank you for your time.